

In the future, each time you browse, you'll be writing to the Web—without your explicit knowledge

Think sites storing your information, sharing your information, so as to display only your stuff. This already happens on sites like Amazon: you see recommendations based on past purchases, and even based on what you browsed for the last time you visited. Now what about even personal Web sites and blogs caching your preferences?

Now head to <http://tinyurl.com/244he3>, and what you'll see is iGoogle—where you personalise pages for others. Examples: "You love your pics. So will your loved ones. Share a series of your favorite photos with friends and family." "Personal List: With this gadget you can publish your own personal "Top Ten" or simply send a set of chores to your sweetie."

These things you send to your sweetie (or anyone else), and his or her Google page gets personalised. Then, consider that communities might make pages for themselves. Think "weGoogle"—your own community creating your page for you.

Now take a look at GoogleAlert (not affiliated with Google), at www.googlealert.com. The site "Tracks Your interests on the Web." "You can use Google Alert to keep track of anything, including information regarding yourself, your work, or your interests."

The idea? We realised the possibility and potential of an app that crawls the Web as you browse, picking up your interactions, and brings up a new "Default Page" for you after it's gathered enough. If it did this constantly, what you'd have is your Personalised Internet always on your browser. Think of it this way: Web 2.0 is sometimes called the read-write Web. What we're saying here is that in the future, each time you browse, you'll

be writing to the Web—without your explicit knowledge—and the next time you read it, it'll be different; it'll be closer to what you want.

We tried to see if someone was actually working in that direction. Turns out lots of people are. The idea is "Reconnaissance Agents": here's from <http://tinyurl.com/2ep5dy>. "Every click on a Web link is a leap of faith. Until you actually see what is behind the link, you don't know whether it will lead to the reward of another interesting page, or to the disappointment of a 'junk' page. But what if you had an assistant that was always looking ahead of you—clicking on the Web links and checking out the page behind the link before you got to it? An assistant that, like a good secretary, had a good idea of what you might like. The assistant could warn you if the page was irrelevant or alert you if that link or some other link particularly merited your attention. (Such agents) will soon become as common as search engines... They are called reconnaissance agents."

Henry Lieberman of MIT's Media Laboratory speaks of Letizia, "an agent that assists Web browsing." As you use a regular browser, the agent tracks your behaviour (the write-to-the-Web we were talking about) and tries to divine what you might like to look at by exploring links from the current link—looking at many links simultaneously, all by itself.

What we'll need to track is whether reconnaissance agents do become as popular as search engines, as Lieberman claims... if and when they do, and if sites exchange information about you like we said, we'll be well on our way to each of us seeing an iWeb. ☒

In It All, Together

Social networking is a phenomenon, nothing short of that. What could it possibly evolve into?



It is believed in some circles that social networking will surpass porn as the most-done activity on the Web. It has also been suggested that Yahoo! and other portals may have to eventually team with MySpace and other similar sites to retain mindshare. The numbers are important: registered Facebook users went from about 6 million in January 2006 to about 13 million in January 2007. Then make that 15 million in March! Then, MySpace membership numbers are growing by about 5 million a month. Sure, many of these accounts are inactive, but the figures are large.

We're talking perhaps the biggest online phenomenon we've seen in many years—the whole "community" thing. Communities might direct the content people access... and traditional media will be the weaker for it. A near-perfect example is Digg: it's almost reached search engine status in some areas. Need technology news? Head to Digg, and sort by Digs. Less authority, more democracy.